A Pocket for the Map

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 5

Rain pattered softly on the riverbank. The ferry waited at its dock, tied by a stout rope. Your wagon stood on dry ground beside it. Inside the explorer case were the original map and two recovered sections. The newest line pointed toward the ferry's little island.

Lark opened the umbrella before opening the case. Its broad roof sheltered every scrap of paper.

“The map can wait here while we make a cover,” Lark explained calmly.

Nib was already drawing a plan. It had wheels, seven poles, a roof, and a little shelf for a snack.

“A portable palace for precious paper,” Nib proclaimed enthusiastically.

Lark looked at his drawing. Then she looked at the ferry.

“Could our palace fit in a pocket?” Lark asked hopefully.

Nib added a very large pocket to his picture. Then he rubbed it out.

“Perhaps we should begin with the paper,” Nib conceded thoughtfully.

They unrolled the picnic mat beneath the umbrella. Lark showed you its familiar label without reading it first.

“Try this word,” Lark invited gently. “Look right through to the last letter. You can join the sounds or ask me to help.”

The mat made a dry work surface. Nib laid spare weatherproof cloth across it, with two stiff backing boards from the packing kit. Small pegs and fastening clips rattled in a tin beside his paws.

Lark touched her lips together, then released one little puff of air.

“Listen: /p/,” Lark modeled clearly. “This is lowercase p. Lips together, then a small pop. No extra vowel. Paper and pocket begin with that sound. Find p beside t.”

Nib folded the cloth around one backing board. He tested the fold with a peg. It stayed closed without needing even one palace tower.

Lark laid out m, a, and t. She moved the last letter away and put p in its place.

“Mat ended with /t/,” Lark explained softly. “Now listen all the way through: /m/, /a/, /p/. Map. Join our new word with me.”

Nib made a second flat cover for the picnic mat. The covers had the same cloth, the same shape, and the same little fastenings. One would hold the map on its backing. The other would carry the mat.

“Very good pockets,” Nib declared proudly. “A little difficult to tell apart.”

Lark wrote a label on each. She left a practice space in the journal, too.

“Write p beside our pocket drawing,” Lark invited warmly. “A line down, then a little round part beside its top. You can trace my first one if you want.”

The new letter stood beside the picture. Nib lifted the two covers by their edges. Their labels faced you: map and mat.

“We need the cover for our paper,” Lark reminded you gently. “Read both words. Which one says map?”

Lark kept the paper sheltered while Nib slid it onto its backing in the chosen cover. The matching mat cover stayed beside it. No corner had to bend to fit.

One peg remained open at the last fold.

“I'll keep the paper flat,” Lark offered calmly. “Nib will hold the cover. Put this peg on the little clasp so our fold stays closed.”

The peg gripped the cloth. Nib pressed the fold once, lightly, as if tucking a blanket around a sleeping map.

Lark caught a raindrop on the umbrella's edge and let it fall onto the outside of the folio. The drop shone, rolled, and slipped away. When she checked inside, the paper was dry.

“Perfectly dry,” Nib murmured proudly. “And considerably smaller than a palace.”

Lark drew the two labeled folios in the journal.

“Why did we give the paper a cover?” Lark asked gently. “What might the rain have done if the old map were left out?”

The shower thinned to a few bright drops. You could see the island shelter beyond the reeds. Lark packed the map folio safely in the case. Nib put the mat in its own matching cover and returned the spare pegs and clips to the kit.

Then he slipped an apple into an ordinary pocket.

“Paper pocket. Picnic pocket,” Nib counted contentedly. “An orderly expedition.”

The ferry stayed tied beside the bank. Your map was protected, your supplies were packed, and the island could wait until everyone was ready to travel.